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Ed Polcer

Cornetist Ed Polcer is an active advocate for American jazz. He was born in Paterson, NJ on February 10, 1937 and was able to visit the thriving club scene of New York City as a youth where he heard numerous jazz legends. He attended Princeton University and joined Stan Rubin's Tigertown Five. Ed has been at the forefront of presenting informative and entertaining productions to new jazz audiences, including "A Night At Eddie Condon's" and "The Magic of Swing Street." He was the manager of Eddie Condon's in New York from 1975 until 1985, and has served as President of the International Art of Jazz. An active traveler and performer, Ed may be seen at many of the jazz parties and festivals across the country.

Ed was interviewed in Tarrytown, New York on October 31, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe. We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Tarrytown, and I'm quite pleased to have Ed Polcer, cornetist and one man vanguard to keep jazz and swing alive in this country.

EP: Thank you.

MR: I shouldn't say one man I suppose, because there's other people out there.

EP: There are many people.

MR: Many doing it. But it seems to be quite a passion of yours.

EP: Yes. I've always had that passion to go beyond just the playing. I don't like the word preservation but the perpetuation of this great music, and I think I enjoy the promoting of it and the band leading as much as I do the playing.

MR: You were born in the very hottest part perhaps of the Swing Era —

EP: Right.

MR: —when you were born, so I don't know, maybe that has something to do with it.

EP: Well I don't know. I was born in 1937 so by the time I began listening to music as a youngster, my father was a trumpet player in a polka band so he had no connection with jazz, but my uncle played with Ben Bernie and traveled to Europe so I had a jazz influence in the family, so I think by the mid-40s I mean I was already listening to records that my uncle would be sending over. And that was a resurgence, well I guess you still had Swing Street going in the 40s. I somehow got interested in the swing rather than the bebop that was coming. So yes I started in the 40s listening.

MR: The bebop at the time was a little more challenging for the listener, it kind of abandoned the dance end of things. Did it have any effect on your listening do you suppose?

dances in high school. It was five days a week. The Student Council would charge two cents admission and with that money that they'd collect every day, once a week we'd go out and buy records. And of course at that time there were still Tommy Dorsey's "Boogie Woogie," and Benny Goodman and a few others. So in addition to the pop singers in the early 50s, because I was president of the Student Council, I'd go out and buy some jazz records, and kids were dancing every noontime in the gym. It was incredible. It would last a half an hour during noontime. So I enjoyed, I guess what I was saying, I enjoyed the dancing part of it and the swing, and I think I shied away a little bit from the bebop, where the beat got a little bit more intricate and demanded more of the audience. I just got hooked on the interaction of the dancing and the people.

MR: That's pretty interesting that the high school kids would be doing that much dancing. Nowadays it seems like touching each other —

EP: Well that was the end of that era. It was 1956 when I was in college, when Bill Haley came in with "Rock Around the Clock," and that was really a jitterbug tune, in fact I think Cliff Lehman, Eddie Condon's drummer, was the drummer on that album.

MR: Oh, no kidding.

EP: Well if you think of it, "Rock Around the Clock," it was just —

MR: It was swing, yeah.

EP: It was just a swinging thing. But from there on, I don't know what the point was —

MR: We were talking about the kids dancing.

EP: Why they would dance — they did — we did touch dance at that time in the '50s. I mean I was in high school from '50 through '54. And that was wonderful. It was only later on maybe getting into almost the '60s where the separate dancing came in.

MR: I want to come back to that, "Rock Around the Clock" in a bit. But you started out on like xylophone or a mallet type instrument?

EP: Yeah. Basically I was already young for my year in school. I started school I think I was four and a half, and the teachers, one of the teachers said, after first grade said, "You really don't have to stay in second grade." I was pretty smart. And since I was already young for the age, another teacher came to my folks and said, "Instead of skipping him into third grade, why don't we give him some outside interest to take up his time and things." And I couldn't — I was too young to play the trumpet, my father played the trumpet, because my second set of front teeth weren't firm and we were not rich enough to buy a piano, so my father went out and bought a xylophone and I learned to play xylophone before piano. I still play vibes occasionally but not on a professional level. But I do think it was important also because I think it's important that — it's helpful for musicians to play an instrument where they can visualize the notes. I mean when you see

much — but in a way I can almost picture those notes, having played visually. And so until my second set of front teeth came in and firmed up I played xylophone. My sister sang. She was four years old, I was seven years old, and we were appearing in church minstrel shows and benefits and oh all kinds of stuff — talent contests. So we got started early. I loved the applause right from the start.

MR: So you were learning to accompany also, on the xylophone?

EP: I guess in a way, yeah. If you can picture a four year old standing on a milk crate, because to get up to the level of the microphone singing "The Things We Did Last Summer," I mean this is like 1944 or so, in a show, a four-year-old girl singing "The Things We Did Last Summer."

MR: Too bad we don't have it on video.

EP: Right.

MR: But was it in your mind, in your father's mind, that you were going to play the trumpet when you were old enough?

EP: Yeah. I think it just became a natural thing and he played in a polka band, he had come over from Austria-Hungry, so I'm really first generation American. And every Sunday during the summer months he would be playing with a polka band at picnics and stuff, and I would sit alongside him and play second and third trumpet in the polka band. I don't think it was anybody's intent that I would get into music full time. Even then, economically it was a struggle kind of a thing to consider that. But I think they always wanted music as a part of my life. And we always had music around the house.

MR: Did they play polka music in the house on records?

EP: Not really, not too much of it, no. My father would bring home a whole smattering of trumpet players, Harry James, you know the things that he was doing, and trumpet players in general.

MR: When you were sitting by him in the polka bands, was it written music?

EP: Yes, it was all written. A lot of triple time [scats]. Very similar really to two beat jazz. In fact it's one of the things that I notice when I play in Germany. I think one of the reasons — my theory on one of the reasons that Germans love this red hot jazz, and they really love traditional jazz, it's very similar to the polka. I mean [scats]. And if you go out to the west coast and hear the Turk Murphy offshoots, the 50 or so bands that are out there, it's banjo and tuba, and it's two-beat [scats]. And you can polka to that whole thing. And I think it's why a lot of the older people do like this two-beat music, they can walk to it, they walk on one and three, as opposed to clapping on two and four.

MR: That's a great point.

EP: I think there's quite a bit of validity in that. It makes it easy for some people to dance to, one and three. They can walk, they can parade, they can carry their umbrellas like New Orleans. So anyway.

MR: That's quite a scene.

EP: So anyway, Ken Peplowski, who I work with a lot, also played for a polka band out in the Cleveland, Ohio area. He cut his chops, got going with that fast clarinet playing from playing polkas. That's what got him into it anyway.

MR: It serves you well I think, technique-wise at least.

EP: Yeah.

MR: You went to Princeton?

EP: Right.

MR: What was your intention when you went to college?

EP: Well first off I was good in math and physics in high school. My father was a worker in a textile mill and his top salary was $90.00 a week, and for me to get a scholarship to Princeton which I did, it was based on need, it was an honor and also since I was good in math and physics it was the design of my advisors and my folks that I would major in engineering, which is what I did. I spent four years majoring in engineering, got out, and within six years I'd pretty much given up most of the engineering background because it really wasn't me. But it was the thing to do, it was a lot of hard work.

MR: I read an interesting anecdote of yours about when you went to Princeton, you wanted to get in on the jazz scene.

EP: Oh, how I was discovered?

MR: Yes.

EP: How I pushed to be discovered.

MR: Yes.

EP: It was like story book. I mean I didn't know Princeton and the Ivy League tradition and anything like that. I mean I was never caught up in it. I never thought I'd go to an Ivy League school. We couldn't afford it. So it was never a thing. All I knew is when I was a kid Dick Hasmeier played football and was all-American and played, and that was Princeton. And every Saturday when I was in high school, Ted Huesing, the radio disc jockey, had a thing called, well he had "Ted Heusing's Bandstand" on WNEW or WINS radio, and for an hour every Saturday morning he'd feature Dixieland or traditional jazz. And every once in a while he would feature Stan Rubin and his Tigertown Five. And Stan was the class of '55, 1955 at Princeton, I was the class of '58. And by the time I got this scholarship and decided to go to Princeton I said I'd love to work with Stan Rubin. He was still there. He was a senior when I was a freshman. So freshman week, I was in

was playing a Dixieland jazz thing and playing very hot, saying somebody's going to hear me. And the first time I tried this, I wasn't doing it for more than about a half an hour and suddenly I get a knock on the door. It wasn't Stan Rubin, but it was one of his competitors, Dennis Brady, who had the Nassau Jazz Band, and it took that long for him to ask me to become his cornet player. Stan Rubin heard us, Stan Rubin booked us in Carnegie Hall along with his band, he had the Nassau Jazz Band play a couple of tunes because we were his discovery, and Stan would hire all the greats, I mean, of the traditional era: Max Kaminsky, Buck Clayton, people like that, and they'd each do a set and it would finish off with Stan Rubin and his Tigertown Five. And then the next year Stan went to play at Grace Kelly's wedding, and his regular trumpet player wanted to get paid more money for the job and refused to go, so Stan called me and said do you want to go, and that was — actually the summer before that Stan booked us on a Holland America line ship where we went to Europe, we played on a student ship and came back, so I had a tour of Europe after my freshman year of college. So I was welcomed into the jazz community very nicely, I had all the ups and none of the downs at that point.

MR: Were your tastes changing at all as you went along? Let's say by the time you graduated you were in your early 20s. Your tastes pretty much stayed with the traditional jazz at that time?

EP: Well it paid my way through school so I knew it had an economic thing. And Dixieland or New York Swing, Eddie Condon stuff had a resurgence in the '50s, and so I stayed with that because it was very popular at all the colleges. And since it was still popular for me, as soon as I graduated college I still gravitated to the Condon kind of guys. I sat in and played and subbed at Condon's a couple of times. Most of my gigs were — I don't like the word traditional but I guess it's so long ago that people call it traditional now. It was really New York Swing. I mean it wasn't two-beat jazz, it was straight ahead swing. I mean eventually I'd work with all kinds of players: Teddy Wilson, Bobby Hackett, Joe Venuti. It was a good run of really swing music, and then Benny Goodman — eventually Hackett recommended me to him, so I played with Goodman for nearly a year but that was later on. My tastes? I gravitated from early listening to Wild Bill Davison with the Condon band but then I got to like Bobby Hackett and of course I got to know Bobby Hackett because we played together quite often at some of the things I promoted in Jersey, and people like Buck Clayton. I guess my hero, who I gravitated toward most was Ruby Braff and sort of that middle swing; semi-modern but still good solid swing. And that's where I gravitated and that's where I still prefer to be, in that kind of pocket there.

MR: You must have occasion where you try to explain the differences — what there are — between New Orleans Dixieland, Chicago jazz and New York swing as you called it. Can

EP: Well no. How much tape do you have here? It would take quite a while. And again it's the critics that put the handles on it. A player goes and plays, right? I consider the music I'm playing right now current. I'm playing music of today. For me it's music of today. It's the music that I hear. It's like a composer or a painter. He can paint the way he feels. But I mean traditional, real New Orleans, was a lot of ensemble playing. Aside from Louis Armstrong, who grew out of that with solos, it was almost entire ensemble playing. So when he went and influenced the fellows in Chicago, the Eddie Condons and the Benny Goodmans, they heard him, they heard his band, which had ensemble playing as well as solos. So what you call the "Chicago style" where the band takes a chorus up front with an ensemble, a fairly close knit ensemble of course, and then each guy gets a chance to play a solo and you have a ride out chorus or two where one is a little tighter and one is free-wheeling, that's kind of the Chicago style. I mean this is being very simplistic. So Condon comes to New York, and it becomes kind of the New York style. Okay it's the New York style of jazz, which is basically, Condon's New York thing was basically the Chicago style. And then you have ragtime, the ragtime piano player, the real two-beat, and then you've got the California banjo-tuba-bass on Turk Murphy, and you have all these offshoots that they become regionalized and you have swing, then you have mainstream then you have bebop, and then straight ahead. What is straight ahead jazz? Tell me that one. Everybody that's playing jazz is playing straight ahead jazz. So I'm saying critics have put these handles on, and they tend to pigeon-hole the players. Oh he's a traditionalist, oh he's this. Players that I know just want to — oh here's the band on this occasion. Now we just settle in. If I'm with a modern tenor player and a guitar player, I'm much different than when I'm playing with a banjo and a tuba, so who am I? What style am I? But it's tough to really describe these things. Anyway that was a capsulized description.

MR: It was a good answer. When it came down to making a living when you were a young man, you were going to take a crack at being a full time musician.

EP: Oh yeah. This came after I worked for a couple of years in engineering and purchasing, yeah. That was my midlife crisis see. A lot of very fortunate things happened to me at that time. I guess I was in my late 30s and my first marriage, which was very good for several years, sort of petered out as I got more and more involved in music and less and less involved with a business career and the success thing which I think my ex-wife expected me to do. In all fairness to her she married a Princeton grad and probably thought I would put away childish things like playing jazz. But that didn't happen. So at the time our marriage was breaking up I met my present wife who has been a constant, reinforcing my career. She graduated college and majored in speech pathology but ended

player. And so since then I've had this strength behind me to get into music. You know what I'm saying. This massive move to give up my day job and get into music wasn't done alone, it was done with a lot of help. Also my ex-partner, Red Balaban, who I'd been working with when I quit my day job, he put me on a partial salary to go out and book his band, Balaban and Cats. Just at that very time Benny Goodman called me and said, "Hey Ed this is Benny." I said, "Who's this?" "Benny." "Benny?" "Benny Goodman," he said, "can you make a rehearsal next week?" I said, "Well you don't even know how I play." He says, "Well Bobby Hackett just recommended you to me," and he said, "if it's good enough for Bobby it's good enough for me." I show up at a rehearsal with Benny Goodman. This is all happening it was like about one year's time where I quit my day job, my marriage is coming to an end, I met my future wife, and I see that possibly I have economically a way of making it as a full time musician. Balaban ends up being my partner at Eddie Condon's and I eventually buy into the club and become manager and part owner. I worked with Benny Goodman and I'm getting fame within certain parameters. And so becoming a full time musician, even in the middle, it was the mid-1970s this happened, so I'm out of school now fifteen years by this time this is happening. In the 60s it would have been a disaster to get into music full time playing the music that I loved. Rock had taken over completely and there were only six clubs in all of New York City that featured jazz of any kind that was going on. I was promoting stuff in New Jersey at the time. So that was the transition into music full time. I don't know if that was what you had intended me to say.

MR: Yeah. That a certain number of things happened to come together that allowed you to do that.

EP: Right.

MR: And when we talk about rock & roll you said that the 60s was absolutely the worst time. Was that the time where you said something about you went back to Princeton and you realized this?

EP: Well within two years after graduating, by 1960 I was invited back to play at one of the clubs for one of the football weekends. And when I was there as late as 1958 there might have been, on a party weekend, on a football weekend, eight jazz bands from New York at Princeton, cause Princeton is 60 miles, 50 miles from New York, and Princeton had always been a jazz school, a rich heritage and history of having jazz played there. So the eight or so clubs having jazz bands, I went back the next year and we were the only jazz band on the campus. Everything was rock. Bill Haley turned it around. It was the beginning of my junior year when at midnight everybody on campus got together and said we're going to open our windows up and at midnight play "Rock Around the Clock"

Everybody, it must have been near exam weekend or something, an excuse to go out and party. But it was a signal, kind of a signal of what was happening. And by the time all those kids who were in high school when that was popular, now were in college, so rock had taken over. But again it was the interaction, it was the dancing that did it. They didn't listen, they didn't care that much for the words, they could dance to it. And jazz had, the main thrust of jazz had gone into bebop and a much more sophisticated form of playing. It's great music but it really lost the public.

MR: It pushed them towards rock almost.

EP: Yeah. I can't fault it because in art, I mean art takes different patterns. I mean when you compare a realist painting with a Jackson Pollock for instance, you don't even know, you're not even using the same guides. It's a different ball game.

MR: It's interesting when you listen to the early rock, that as you said before, "Rock Around the Clock" is a swing-blues, right?

EP: It's the same tempo as Count Basie's "One O'Clock Jump" and it's a blues. But they use the word "rock." The word rock came in, I mean "Rock Around the Christmas Tree," they used that word, all the pop artists.

MR: When you listen to some of the early Chuck Berry for instance, you almost hear this very interesting conflict because some of the band is still swinging, and Chuck is playing straight eighth notes on his guitar. It's like adjusting itself.

EP: Okay, they were probably, that was probably a link going there to some of the things that evolved later. I mean people say well how do you distinguish between jazz and rock. Well the music evolved from the other. I mean it was swing. Rock came out of jazz. It came out of rhythm and blues. I remember in high school my buddy and I would ride around late at night after a game or something and head to the diner, and on the radio in the car we used to listen to rhythm and blues. This was in the early or mid-fifties. And then rhythm and blues and all that became soul. I mean all these handles that get put on, but there is an evolution. And how far you want to push it, watching MTV, I was watching it last night and some of that stuff is pretty scary where that has — Marilyn Manson and few other things. That has no connection with the music in general. It's weird.

MR: Scary is a pretty good word.

EP: Yeah, Marilyn Manson I would say is pretty scary.

MR: So you got into the Condon — picked up that Condon mantle or whatever it was. Did you enjoy your stint as a club owner?

EP: Oh yeah. It was fantastic. I mean being in a center of my jazz world, owning, playing, band leading, managing and owning a club that represented everything I wanted to say,

coming to New York I was able to go into jazz clubs and plunk myself down at the Metropole, order one beer and sit for three hours and listen to the greatest music possible. So in the face of all these stiff music charges that had been put on all the clubs in New York to quote pay for the music it's made it become more elitist so that the average person can't come in and listen to it and be influenced by the music. So we presented a club there, up to the end we charged any musician who could prove he was a musician, if we didn't know him and he had a union card, he could sit at the bar and drink for a buck and a quarter a drink. We finally upped it to a dollar and a half because some of the guys would come in and order a double Remy Martin and there it is, you got it baby, for a dollar and a half. But musicians came into the club. I mean there were nights where half of the Count Basie band was in there. They had finished a concert elsewhere. They'd come in. Joe Williams would come in and sing with us. He'd come in and the minute he'd come in we'd go into "Rosetta" and he'd [scats] he'd come walking up from the bar and sing. Frank Sinatra. All kinds of people came into that club. It was an exciting place to be for ten years. At the end for me, the administrative part of it and the drudgery of taking inventory of liquor and all that and food and closing up night after night and things, it was physically taxing. It was a glorious ten years though in New York. People would come from all over the world to Eddie Condon's. If it wasn't THE premier club it was one of three worldwide premier jazz clubs. It wasn't any great, lavish place. It was just a jazz joint. It was a saloon, which is what Condon called his place, was a saloon. We served food, decent, a minimal amount of food but it was there. You'd come in. Our philosophy was you didn't have to have a cover charge. If you liked it you'd stay and you'd order another drink. And by the time you're through you'd probably spend the same amount of money that — you didn't have to make a commitment. We advertised in all the local hotels, "music right around the corner" there was no fear of having to get in a cab, walk around New York they could walk two blocks and come to Eddie Condon's and walk back to their hotel. So we had a worldwide, we had our own world wide web right there at Eddie Condon's. It was great. It was glorious.

MR: What's your take on Eddie Condon as to how he fits into the history of jazz? What was his major contribution?

EP: Oh boy. He was a great band leader. He surrounded himself with great musicians. I don't think he gave it that much thought but he actually was in the vanguard of breaking down racial barriers. At the same time that Benny Goodman was putting on his 1938 concert which had blacks and whites in the same band, Condon had his Town Hall concerts where he was doing the same thing. I think he just believed if you could play, you could play. Don't worry about your sex, don't worry about your color. I think he had — and

personal life was in kind of a funny shambles. I mean it was sad, bittersweet, because he drank an awful lot but he loved to party, but he attracted to his club some of the world's, I mean the great people of the world would come, the sports, they even some of them came into us, the carryover, the Condon's that we ran. Walter Cronkite was a jazz fan. Loved Wild Bill Davison. I still correspond with him. So Condon was a very key person. I mean he grew up, he was born in Indiana and was in with those guys in Chicago before coming to New York. So he was in when swing was evolving. He hated the word "Dixieland," and don't ever mention Dixieland to Eddie Condon. We were just playing music. In fact one of his books it's called *We Called It Music*. So he was quite a man, and he knew good jazz, he knew it too. I mean he wouldn't tolerate mediocre, mediocrity.

MR: And who was in your house band while you were there?

EP: Well the first house band involved Jimmy, most of the time Jim Andrews was our piano player and Red Balaban was the bass player. We went through several different drummers, Ronny Cole, Connie Kaye from the MJQ was our drummer for about three years believe it or not, played great drums, in our style, Danny DeImperio, a great drummer from upstate New York came in and did the last three years. I was the cornetist the whole time, the basic one. For a long period of — most of the time was Vic Dickinson on trombone until he got feeble or sick, around two years before the club closed. Tom Artin, a Princetonian friend of mine who I'd played with since 1955, he came in and replaced Vic, in fact Tom Artin in my estimation was one of the better trombone players in the country, not too many people know him. Went through several very good piano players, Herb Hall was the original one, Edmond Hall's brother, he was there for three years with us. He was our original clarinetist and we had Bobby Gordon a very fine I would say Joe Marsala type, Pee Wee Russell influenced clarinetist, a real musician's musician. He now plays in San Diego, California. And we finished with Jack Maheu, who came from, who I guess was one of the co-leaders of the Salt City Six from the Rochester area, Syracuse-Rochester, so he was the clarinetist for the last three years or so. So it was, and we had an agreement with anybody in the band that if you could get another gig elsewhere, a high paying gig or you wanted a night off, just call me and I would get a replacement. So it was almost very seldom that for two nights in a row we'd have exactly the same band, which kept the music kind of alive and you know you don't get so used to playing with the same guys night after night, and each night could become a little different. Just change one out of six and the whole chemistry can change.

MR: And you would just go up — would you go up on the stand and call the tunes as you felt, playing to the crowd somewhat?

EP: That's right. We ended up Red Balaban led the band pretty much three nights and I led it

have the band on Monday nights. I tried changing it a little bit on Monday nights toward the end and had a few modern players, Lew Tabackin I remember working with him one night, Effie Resnick who had gotten quite modern on trombone. I was trying to present a little bit of a more modern flavor, but that was just my indulging myself. But yeah, we'd just go up on the stand and not give it that much thought. I'd look down the songlist, say hey we'll do this, and if we had requests we'd play the requests. It was about as loose as it could get. The music spoke for itself really.

MR: Your own personal tastes of trumpet players — you were influenced by you mentioned a couple of guys, Bobby Hackett, and who was the other earlier —

EP: Well first off there's Louis Armstrong.

MR: Yeah, okay.

EP: I mean the shake or the wobble that I have as a part of my style was really out of Louis, I mean from listening out of Louis and from listening to Louis. And the melodic part I think the combination of me playing the xylophone and seeing those chords [scats] and listening to Hackett and his weaving notes, so I think that's part of my playing is that. The intensity of certain players, Muggsy Spanier and the beautiful intensity of Ruby Braff. Those are probably the strongest influences on me. I don't listen that much anymore. I mean I feel like, I mean to the older style. I'll listen to world music or classical music now as opposed to listening to jazz players. I'm not interested in going into the modern field. I'm too far along the way right now to mess around. And I've had a good success with my style. I like my style. So I don't listen too much now to other players.

MR: That's an important statement. I like my style you said.

EP: Well I've done a lot of listening. It isn't a case of saying well this is me, I'm a natural born, I come with this style and so I've done a lot of listening and I actually occasionally listen to what's being played today and I just, it's lovely but it's not me. So I feel very comfortable where I'm at.

MR: Earlier on you made a statement about — when you were talking about the xylophone — people ask what are you thinking about when you're improvising. You said not much. Can we talk about that for a moment? Because I agree with your statement about how helpful it is to be able to see the chords.

EP: It works in your subconscious someplace. I don't know. What do I think about?

MR: Yeah.

EP: Well first, one of the things I like most about classic jazz which is a nice all around handle that I can put on my spectrum let's say of jazz, is collective improvisation, which has gone down the tubes to a large degree in recent years. There's been much more

thing of listening to the other horns. I mean I find myself in situations where the trombonist or the clarinetist or the saxophone are really playing solos even while you're playing an ensemble chorus. I think what I want to say is what goes through my mind is I do feel the interaction of the other players and I love the interaction with other horn players. But in order to do that you've got to leave spaces and listen to what the other guy is doing. It's almost like playing a duet or a trio. It's one of the beauties of collective improvisation. So what is going through my mind is I am listening to the others players, and I'm saying Oh now the rhythm section just decided to give me a Charleston beat, okay, I'm going to shift my beat and do this, I'm going to lay a few notes down, I'm going to hear what the clarinet or the sax is going to give me back. This is during the ensemble part of the playing. And there are very few players who really are tuned into ensemble playing. Ken Peplowski is marvelous. He believes in leaving a lot of space. The space is important in ensemble playing. Tom Artin is wonderful with his putting the bottom in. He knows when to go up to the upper range on the trombone. Some of it is familiarity from working together in that case. But still, I love the collective thing. And when I am playing a solo, I don't know what I'm thinking of. I might have had some classical music in the back of my head that I listened to earlier that day, some beautiful melody. I try to create in my solos some kind of continuity. I don't think consciously of leading the audience into my solos but I think that is the bottom line. I've had several people say we love how you're weaving in your solos, we can follow you. And maybe in a way I've kept simpler, I've kept my style simpler rather than fast, rapid technique, I choose to play simpler.

MR: Do you think about the quote safe notes in each chord as they go by, or is that more inherent by now?

EP: I think by the time you get, if you've played as long as I have you know whether your chops are in good shape for instance on the given night, you know whether that band is swinging. If that band is swinging and your chops are in pretty good shape, I'll try anything really, and I'm not worried about making a mistake. I've got enough confidence that what's the worst that's going to happen? I'm going to get fired? My reputation is going to go down the tubes because of one mistake or something? I'm not worried about it. I'd rather make it exciting. Even in the recording studio. I've seen some guys clutch up the minute — I know that they can really play hot. You put them on a record date in a recording studio, they will, everything is safe. And I'll say afterwards "that isn't you, man" I say don't worry. Make a mistake. If worse comes to worse we'll run it again. Well now you can edit in the note, edit out the note. But give me your best. I think that I probably, just strength wise, probably peaked maybe five or six years ago as far as high

aging, maturity, call it what you want. I choose my notes but it's a matter of choice. I don't think I — I listened to myself when I thought I was great, playing very intense stuff, and I haven't liked it as much as I thought I did when I was playing it. You know what I mean? So I'm a firm believer in simplicity. Vic Dickinson was the master of that and I played next to him for eight of the ten years we were at Condon's. Just a master of simplicity. And he had marvelous technique, but he would just lay it out there, those beautiful melodies. So I love that.

MR: When players in the 60s came along — Coltrane, Miles Davis — the music seemed to get, some of it, pretty angry. Was it something you listened to? Did it have an effect on you?

EP: I just walked away from — I was not that interested. Some of the beautiful Miles Davis, you know the beautiful things, I loved it. The other agendas that go with the playing, the attitudes and things, I try not to let that get in the way of my playing. I think by that time I already had decided kind of where I was going to go musically and didn't want to get into a lot of that, I thought it would mess my style. Of course I was working in the 60s, I was still working days, I hadn't made my commitment to go full time. And it was very shaky to get into music. It was precarious. It was kind of dangerous to consider being a full time musician. And hearing how great these guys were, they weren't all that successful financially so I didn't go that route. When the time came, remember it was Benny Goodman called me to play with him. Red Balaban, who played in the Condon tradition was going to open a night club, he hired me to book his band, so I was very secure in the swing idiom and it's almost like I didn't want to go down that road. And the angriness that has taken hold in much of music and much of jazz and much of the music of today, I don't want any part of it. When I came to New York in 1958 after college, I mean yes if I were a black at that time I probably would not be telling you the same thing I'd be telling you now. But for me, a white, I was welcomed. I mean I would see Al Casey up on St. Nicholas Avenue, I'd hire him on a job and take him and wait while he brought his guitar up and came back for his amp. I dated my wife in Harlem. We went to the Baby Grand. I was welcomed into the jazz community and there weren't a lot of agendas going on at the time. Jazz was not black. Jazz was for everybody. Now it's very polarized with what's going on. So I don't buy into all that anger. And jazz is European. I mean jazz, granted it started in the States, but you go to Europe and you've got some pretty fine players over there. Jazz is music. Music is for everybody. And it's not our music. So the angriness never, I just walked away from it. I'm going through life once, I'm going to have fun. What other jobs can you think of where you go to work and everybody wants to have a good time. I mean how many people go to an office where it's

great time. So let's have a great time together. I don't believe in goofing off or hacking around, I mean I've very, I set pretty high professional standards for myself and the fellows around me, but I mean let's have a good time and play some darn good music.

MR: Is it a form of art for you?

EP: Pardon?

MR: Is it a form of art for you?

EP: Oh, jazz itself is a cause celebre. It is an art. And my motivation, it's the reason I am on the face of the earth, is to play good jazz music, and doing all the things that I'm doing, promoting other players, promoting concerts, working for, I don't anymore, but International Art of Jazz, doing stuff in schools, doing stuff in the public, carrying on The Magic of Swing Street out in Boise, Idaho and Cut Bank Shelby, Montana, you know in Cut Bank Shelby is one of the great Duke Ellington fans, a lady, a Native American up there she's about in her eighties, Duke Ellington stayed at her house, she came on the bandstand and requested us to do some esoteric, some lesser known Duke Ellington piece. We couldn't play it. She got up and played it. I mean these are the things, these are the things that count. I mean go out there and bring this music to people. This is me. I believe in this music. If you like it, wonderful, I welcome you into my world. So it's a cause, yeah, it's a cause. I don't want to, this is how I motivate myself. I don't go out in public and say you've got to believe, but hey, let's have some fun, let's take our walk down Swing Street. Now here's a tune that they did back then but we love doing it today.

MR: This concept of "The Magic of Swing Street," when did it kind of come together for you?

EP: Well Community — Columbia Artists came to a concert I did in 1992 up at the Emelin Theater up in Westchester. I invited them because I knew that they have probably five or six hundred venues throughout the United States, an organization called Community Concerts. And what they do is, it started out as a classical Columbia Records or Columbia Recordings started it many years ago, 75 or 80 years ago, as an outlet for their artists and what they did was a small community would get up a budget let's say of $30,000 okay. Community Concerts would go out and say well we can bring you The Kirov Ballet, we can bring you Ed Polcer and his jazz band, we can bring you a concert pianist, we can bring you a circus act, and that will all fit your budget. So that year, in Cut Bank Shelby, Montana, you can have some of the greatest entertainment in the world, and all it's going to cost you as a person is maybe $20 for the whole concert series. So they get this budget going, and so I knew about Columbia Artists. But I just didn't want to have just the jazz concert, I felt that it was a perfect opportunity of bringing, in an entertaining way, the music. In other words a little story that went along, so effectively it's like a mini-show but it's basically a jazz concert. Instead of just getting

Night at Eddie Condon's." And we toured for three -- two years with that. And we must have hit maybe 120 different concerts just doing that. And I went to the people at Columbia Artists and said I'd like another go-around and I've got a great idea for another show that we could do and they came up with the title, "The Magic of Swing Street." I said you know we could show going beyond what — "A Night at Eddie Condon's" described what went on at Eddie Condon's and it showed the influences of all the influences coming from all over the country to come into that Chicago style playing that we had whether it was Benny Moten. Anyway, it looked at jazz from the influences on the music that was played at Eddie Condon's. So this other was hey, come and take a walk with us down New York Swing Street. There was only one time in the history of the world where all the forms of classic jazz was played. This is my opening line. And it was New York's 52nd Street, Swing Street, for 20 years from 1935 to 1955. What was played there? Traditional. Dixieland. Ragtime. New Orleans. Blues. Chicago style. Mainstream. Bebop. Where it was like an artist's colony for musicians, and it really must have been. I only caught the tail end of it, but I mean to walk down that street there were 40 jazz clubs in two city blocks, and for twenty years music poured forth on this street and musicians could learn from each other. The style of swing reached its maturity there. The traditionalists could hear the swing players, they could hear the bebop players, they could feed off one another. And it was just a wonderful time to be. And when you get into some of the songs that came out of that time, I mean some people in the audience I mean would be in tears. It encompassed World War II for crying out loud, we had some of the prettiest and saddest love songs ever written. And the jazz bands were playing those too. And some of the people, the more elderly ones in the audience, would remember what it was like in the 40s. And whether they'd been to New York or not, I was giving them, we were giving them a trip to New York here in your own armchair in your own, in Cut Bank Shelby, Montana. So that's in a way it's a hook and it provided wonderful work for our bands and wonderful chance — Condon's closed in '85, they tore it down to make way for another office building, so that motivated me to, if you can't come to my club to hear us, I'll try to bring it to you. And again it goes beyond just a jazz concert. It's got a little story that goes with it. And people, even the jazz fans, I've done this at some of the jazz festivals, and in the face of just pretty what should I say laid-back jazz musicians, I decided I was not going to worry about, I'd have the courage of my convictions and I'd go and say look can I do a set of "The Magic of Swing Street" at one of these jazz festivals. And they said yeah why don't you. So I do my hour set and people would come up afterwards, even the hard core jazz fans, that was great, I didn't know that, you said this story here, that was a great story. I didn't know that about Count Basie and the air

band they'd put in air conditioning. You know, things like this. So it brings you down on a personal level. It makes the audience feel that they're part. It breaks down the wall between the player and the audience.

MR: Which is the way the music was supposed to be.

EP: Which I believe, the music that I believe in was. Whether some music works better with — you're in awe of that great performer. But I think even the great ones, Andre Watts is a wonderful, he knows classical music. He knows why he's going to pick a program and do this tune and do this one and this one led from here to here. All of a sudden the audience can share so much more with you. So that's where "The Magic of Swing Street" came in, in the face of whether — you know I just decided I was going to do it. And everybody has fun doing it. And it provides a lot of work for guys.

MR: What's your association been, or experience in trying to get your music recorded?

EP: Not very good. Concord never was interested. I mean the fellow, I forget his name, he used to come into Condon's all the time.

MR: Jefferson?

EP: Yeah. He came in there a couple of times and I figured he would ask me to record for him and never did. And that probably was, it didn't leave me feeling too good about it. The one who has recorded what I've done again is the traditional Jazzology, George Buck in New Orleans, but that was through the help of Phil Carroll who runs the Atlanta jazz party. He knew that I had not been recorded that much and so what he did was set up a recording session after one or, actually four or five of these Atlanta jazz festivals, and through the auspices of Jazzology out of New Orleans they recorded me, that's mail order. And the other two I promoted myself for these concert tours. "A Night at Eddie Condon's" and "The Magic of Swing Street." I've been on two of the tours of Europe and Germany. And every year Nagel Heyer and Hamburg records whoever's touring for the Manny Salchof. And I went over and led "A Tribute to Eddie Condon."

MR: Is that what this came from? The CD?

EP: Yeah, that's the Nagel Heyer. And I also last year went over with Terry Blaine, a very fine straight ahead vocalist with her "Too Hot for Words, the Great Ladies of Swing" concert. We toured all over and they recorded us there on that but that was Terry Blaine and Mark Shane. It's not easy to get recorded playing the style I am.

MR: When you go to the jazz parties these days, there's so much product out there, the CDs and so forth. I'm wondering, it must be hard to sell enough to really get any return on it.

EP: Yeah. If you're going to produce them yourself, actually you can produce them pretty inexpensively. I mean let's face it. I mean if you do, even by musician's scale, if you say for 20 minutes of recorded time you need a three hour session, for about a thousand

absolute perfection and arrangements. But if you're doing the kind of music I like it's pretty free-wheeling and if you've got a tape you just roll, you go on to the next tune and you roll. If there's a clinker in there, so what? It's jazz. So therefore, as a leader, with five guys it costs you $5,000 for the musicians. You've probably done the session in six hours, so that's six hours of studio time at $75 an hour, that's $450 of studio time. The mixing maybe another 4 hours, 5 hours. Cassettes, I mean CDs cost you about a dollar apiece for the CD, with the case and with the artwork, it should not have to cost you more than about $2.00 a CD. So once you've absorbed the thousand, let's say $2,000 of studio time and musicians, if you buy a thousand CDs, the CDs are going to cost you $2.00 apiece and you're going to have $3.00 apiece is going to be your cost, so your first thousand, the cost of your CDs is about $5 apiece, and you sell them for $15 or $20. It's the only way to do it. But you need an outlet. And yes, at the jazz festivals you're competing with so many of the other players at jazz parties, there's so many CDs out there you're not going to do it. But if you've got any number of concert gigs you can — so you sell a thousand a year, that's 15 grand, right? And that's only a thousand a year. But another thing, and I've compared my notes with other players is that if you see an audience of people who really are liking what you're doing, if there's a thousand people in the audience you will average a thousand dollars in sales for that concert, as long as it's your CD that's out there. So what you're saying is a little under ten percent of the people will buy a CD. And it averages out. Every once in a while you'll get double that and other ones you'll merely bomb out. So having those concerts for Columbia Artists, financially it was great with the CDs.

MR: Do you enjoy playing these jazz parties? You get to invite all the different musicians?

EP: Yeah. I like the jazz parties as opposed to the jazz festivals where they have organized bands. Yes, the parties are wonderful where they invite anywhere from 15 to 30 musicians, three or four on each instrument and they put you together different combinations. Some of them are good, some of them are not so good, it depends on the attitude of the players that go to some of them. Some are very self — don't want to budge too much and therefore the repertoire ends up being more limited than it could be. In other words it will come down to maybe one of two hundred tunes that everybody knows. And you get tired of playing "Undecided" and "Jumpin' at the Woodside" and a few of the other tunes, and "One O'Clock Jump" or, you know, "Don't Get Around Much Anymore" or "Satin Doll." I mean they're all great tunes but you get there and you've got six guys, okay now what are we going to do guys? If the leader on a given set really puts in some time ahead of time and says okay I've got a great swing set here or I've have a very traditional set, let's do a traditional set, and so it depends how much time you put in

on it and some guys don't, some of the players just go and they're kind of lackadaisical about it. So some of the festivals are good, some of them aren't. It's not all wonderful.

MR: How about playing overseas like in Europe?

EP: Very appreciative audiences. I tried living in Paris for six months and living there on European musician's terms is not economically very good. This is a while ago when I lived — this is 1963, and I mean I was working for eight dollars a night and fifteen dollars a night. I tried living in Paris for six months and traveling around Europe. But going over there as an American with pre-booked gigs, you're getting the best of everything. You're treated nicely and the audiences really do love you. Japan the same way. But I've had a good run here in the States, because of the narrative and because of being friendly with the audiences. I mean I think every audience I play for I have a good time and I think they do.

MR: There's a lot to be said for giving the audience credit and wanting to include them in what you're doing. I mean jazz musicians considered themselves entertainers, didn't they?

EP: Yeah. I mean you see what the Ellington band wore and the way that the sections would move, if it was good enough for them it's good enough for me. I mean what's this stand up here and be a hero bologna? Let's have some fun. Let's get into it.

MR: Have you had much occasion to visit colleges, and work with college age students?

EP: Not much. I just put an ad in *Jazz Times*, now available, one of the masters of the jazz cornet Ed Polcer would like to take you on a stroll down Swing Street and perhaps conduct a seminar also if you want involving the business side of music. Things we're talking about today. I mean I think it could be great for some of the young people. I think it's a facet that they don't get. I think if you get clinicians, a lot of musicians are wonderful technicians, I don't think they can deal with the business side or the history of it, that say I could do. I could present some things for kids to think about. The fact that I spend eight hours a day or six hours a day on the phone and doing paperwork and following up and organizing bands and making those cold calls — hey would you like to book my band? I'm trying to do stuff with the symphony now. I've got eight arrangements for jazz band and symphony. We did two symphony concerts last year. A whole new market for new audiences. But try and buck the symphony. They don't want to do Pops concerts for starters most of the symphonies, they feel it's a necessary evil. For them it's like putting on a red vest and playing Dixieland jazz for a picnic, I mean for them playing a Pops concert. So trying to make that sale. But when you talk to kids it's not just the playing. There's an awful lot of administrative work that goes into this thing. And you've got to be prepared and you'd better have some business courses too. If you're

going to major in music, take some business courses. But not to be the business of music, but —

MR: Just general knowing —

EP: Just general knowing business and getting to like people, the whole thing.

MR: Speaking of liking people, did you enjoy your stint with Benny Goodman?

EP: Yes. I had — well I mean we were treated like kings by the audiences I mean the thrill of my opening night, 18,000 people, I mean I was shaking so much that we played "Let's Dance" and I'm [scats]. I mean literally I couldn't stop shaking. And I had nothing but good experiences with Benny myself. He always was very supportive of me. And what I liked in his later years, which is what I was a part of is that he liked surrounding himself with younger players. It made him feel I think more vital. And it also provided an awful lot of us, here and forevermore I can include in my bio that I played with Benny Goodman. And it's a mark of credibility. You know your credentials. So it was a great experience. The first time that I really got treated like most musicians should be treated all the time, as a celebrity. It was great.

MR: There sure are a lot of places in the country now that you can go to study jazz.

EP: Yes.

MR: Do you feel that there needs to be more emphasis on the audience for jazz? Maybe I'm spouting my own feelings here.

EP: Well let me say this. My son is majoring, just decided to major in jazz performance at the University of Michigan. And he already knows the business side from watching me in action. And already I'm feeling that he could get, there should be more given to him other than just the pure music part of it. Is that what you're trying to say? Well the business side of it. The personality, all this kind of stuff. It was a great article, Wynton, who I disagree with on a lot of points wrote this great article, it was in *Jazz Times* about what is some of the things that are lacking in teaching at college level, and it has to do with performance and liking the audience and everything else. I mean I'll send it to you. Maybe I didn't hear your question.

MR: Well I guess I look at all the players coming out of the jazz programs and many of them are really, really good. I'm wondering where they're going to go with it if there's no audience for it, and if there's something we could do, and I guess what you're doing here with the Swing Street —

EP: I don't, you know I think a lot of the teacher's don't really have, are that fully aware of what the world is like out there as a jazz musician, I mean the communication part of it, having to sell your product. Technique is not the only answer. I have to be careful because I don't want to, I don't know enough about what is being taught really. I do

think enough time is spent on collective improvisation, small band work. The real world, let's face it, is not going to be a big band reading those parts. And I do not like a lot of the solos put out by great technicians, I just feel that they've learned things almost by rote, by too much Arban book and not enough simple stuff. All the things I've been talking about. My whole philosophy I think a lot of it is lacking in the music school. We didn't have that much in music schools, because we did it by playing. Of course jazz was the music of the time you know and so I think these are substitutes now, you've got to create a lab band, you've got to create a big band, you've got to take one course and they divide you up into six small group improvisation things and you try to pick the best guys to work together and you're creating the, you have to create the situations that happened automatically when I was in school. I was fortunate enough to play every weekend at a party where people were loving it, you know, playing our music. I think it's coming back with swing dancing, I think younger people are getting interested much more so. My son is out in Michigan, has already got three or four clubs in Ann Arbor where they have jazz. I stopped at one place and I saw him sit in one night. I mean and he's just starting and they encouraged him. So there are natural settings for this music and I do think the involvement of young people in dancing can turn a corner unless they just make it a fad and just say this is retro. If the Squirrel Nut Zippers and their leader, from what I read about him he's genuine and if they are not going to be a typical retro band maybe they will set a standard. But I do see young people, I played a club in Westchester, a new jazz club, The August Lounge, out there were college aged kids learning how to they call it swing dancing, it's jitterbugging, I mean tossing each other over the shoulder, practicing right on the dance floor. I played a job at Columbia University — boy I'm talking too much here — last year with a fraternity party where the kids were lined up. They were charging admission for kids from other fraternities for kids to come for their annual swing dance. There must have been 300 people in this fraternity house, on 110th Street in New York City. Swing dancing. It was wonderful. So maybe there will — I don't know I guess I hedged a little bit because I really don't want to start attacking what's going on in schools but I do think if some of the things that I was talking about were covered, kids would, young people — I hate the word kids — young people would be aware of what the real world is. And maybe the teachers, some of them are not quite up to the task of for instance collective improvisation. If a teacher's tastes are bebop and a kid come here with a more traditional thing, who's going to say what? You're improvising wrong? What are you going to do? It was like before Little League baseball we went up and played baseball in the hayfields in Prospect Park, New Jersey. That's where we learned as kids. It wasn't all so organized. So maybe with the swing dancing kids will be, there will be

campus in the eastern seaboard had two or three jazz bands. Some of them were swing, some of them were bebop, some of them were Dixieland. At the Colgate Winter Carnival they'd have a full day Saturday from 10 in the morning until 5 at night, 5 in the evening, one jazz band after another. A solid day of jazz in the auditorium there. All informal groups. Nothing, no auspices. Colleges have had to do it this other way because it's not been, jazz has not been central to the peers and they're not that interested in it so a kid is going to gravitate to play rock or whatever.

MR: Well you're doing your part.

EP: Well, and a lot of the players I work with are too.

MR: Do you want to just show me your weapon of choice here?

EP: It's a fairly beat up, second hand cornet, a Yamaha, and it just has a nice big sound. Again I haven't bought a new horn probably since college, and I'll just play a horn and just like it.

MR: Learn to like it.

EP: Learn to like it. But it has the sound — oh that's another thing I think I don't know whether they're saying it but when a player enters jazz he starts with sound. And the sound that he has or she. Or the sound that you develop. And your improvising should I think have some kind of connection with that. If you have a big fat sound you'd be hard pressed playing a subtle bebop phrase. And if you have a thin, if your body and your horn is giving you a thin sound you're not going to sound like Louis Armstrong. You're going to overblow that horn. So you start with whatever your sound is. That's it.

MR: I love what the mutes can do for an instrument. Do you mind showing me a little bit of that?

EP: What, would you like to hear what the different —

MR: I'd like to hear what they do.

EP: Well the mutes, okay, I love working with mutes because it can change the texture of what you're playing. All right open horn. [audio] Make it ring, all right, okay. So then you take a Harmon mute and you take the stem out and you get close to the microphone and you approximately what Miles [audio] or you can put the stem in and you can sound like some of the Duke Ellington trumpet sections. [audio] really an intense, black, Harlem feel. [audio] the wa-wa, okay. And then you have the good old plunger, which of course again is more traditional, Muggsy Spanier [audio]. You can get that feel too, but [audio] all you're doing is altering the flow of air there.

MR: Available at your local hardware store, right?

EP: And this is a Denis Wick, a British manufacturer, a plastic mute and it's very versatile in that it can become a cup mute [audio] which blends very well with a nice, soft sax, or if

okay, now if I get in a hot duet with somebody playing "China Boy" like on the clarinet [audio] I'm not going to overblow the clarinet.

MR: I love that cup mute. It has such as sound reminiscent of, I don't know, it speaks of a certain era almost.

EP: Oh it's mellow. [audio] It's very intimate for ballad playing. So here I've got one-two-three-four-five-six, six different combinations depending on what I want to make that song do.

MR: I'm jealous as a saxophone player you know.

EP: So anyway.

MR: Well thanks for the demonstration.

EP: Yeah, okay.

MR: What's up for you in the near future?

EP: Well next week I go to three concerts in Raleigh, North Carolina in that area. And two weeks later out in Seattle, Washington for two more. I have a very interesting concert on January 1st at the Museum of Modern Art in New York in connection with the Jackson Pollock art exhibit that opens I think tomorrow on the first of November. And Jackson Pollock was a jazz fan and so they're doing four Fridays in January. We're doing it January 1st, the music that Jackson Pollock liked. Evidently he loved jazz and liked playing along while he painted. So whatever his bizarre paintings were you can blame jazz. But anyway we're doing a thing called "A Night at Nick's" which was the club that predated Condon's with that great New York style jazz and it's all based on his records, Jackson Pollock's record collection. And I'm still working on I've got about eight or nine jazz festivals already booked or jazz parties for next year. I'm still trying hard to book us "The Magic of Swing Street" with symphony orchestras for Pops concerts, and continuing, just continuing on what we've been doing.

MR: Well you can't sit still, that's for sure.

EP: No, there's no way. I mean I've had great role models in my life. Milt Hinton being one, Clark Terry being another. I shouldn't even start naming names. I've had a lot of good role models that man, if you've been given this gift of being able to play and you like people, what better? It would take a couple of million dollars and maybe not even that to make me stop doing what I'm doing. Just, it's a great way.

MR: Well I've enjoyed talking to you.

EP: Likewise, I'm a little bit hoarse here. I've been talking quite a bit.

MR: I know we've fit a lot in. So best of luck, I'm sure we'll meet on the road.

EP: Well best of luck to you and this whole program. I'm really proud for you, of you and what you're doing with this whole program because it goes to the core of who I am too.